

I always believed myself to be financially unlucky to have been born in a middle class family where all of us had to struggle all our lives to first make our ends meet, and then support our family's needs. By the time we could understand money and financials we were already in a trap which was almost impossible to break. It is referred to as the "rat race" in the previous section. You have a family to support and you can never save enough to earn a passive income. The pool of money never grows big enough to sustain inflation and all the expenses that we must incur as a part of our life responsibilities.

It was while reading one of the books on becoming a millionaire⁷ I realized that 80% of America's millionaires are first generation ones. They did it slowly, steadily and without signing any multimillion dollar deals. Read it again — 80% of the millionaires are "self made" and are "first generation"⁸. This fact just cut through the whole "excuse wall" that I had built up around myself.

What this fact essentially meant was that it is not the inherited money that counts; it is the effort and discipline that you put in during your lifetime that makes you rich. So, if you thought you can never be a millionaire, think again.

I went on to read many such books on how people became millionaires and found the following common traits in first generation millionaires:

1. They live well below their means
2. They allocate their time, energy, and money efficiently; in ways conducive to wealth building
3. They strongly believe and live the fact that financial independence is more important than displaying high social status
4. Their parents were not financially well off or even if they were, they did not provide economic support
5. Their adult children are economically self sufficient
6. They married once and remained married
7. They did not fail "because of..." but succeeded "in spite of...". Failure was never an option for them